

TOUGHER THAN NAILS

A study of modern armoured vehicles

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Armoured vehicles form the backbones of the army. Their roles range from simple recon to troop transport to armoured support. Since World War II, armoured vehicles have formed the spearhead of any military invasion, busting through defences and enemy armour alike. Earlier, armoured vehicles simply meant tanks, but now that definition has evolved to encompass a wide variety of vehicles that can be broadly classified as follows:

SOFT VEHICLES

A comparatively uninteresting category. These are usually standard civilian vehicles that have been modified for better off-road performance.

Unarmed soft vehicles

These are basically trucks and 4x4s that are primarily designated for troop transport and, in some cases, recon. These vehicles can be maimed or destroyed by almost any kind of firearm.

Armed soft vehicles

These are soft vehicles that are outfitted with mounted machine guns and grenade launchers and in some cases, even ATGMs (Anti-Tank Guided Missiles). Such vehicles are still very vulnerable to any kind of attack, but they can adequately defend themselves in a pinch. The ATGMs are particularly useful for hit-and-run attacks when facing armoured vehicles.

ARMOURED VEHICLES

These are vehicles that are the true backbone of any army. They offer distinctly

better protection than the unarmoured variety. This class of vehicles is primarily designed to be "aggressively employed" during combat, hence the armour. Based on armour and armament, these vehicles can be broadly classified as follows:

Light armour

These are vehicles such as the Plasan SandCat and the more popular Humvees that are still in operation. These vehicles



The age-old humvee is still a reliable tool

provide reasonably effective protection from small arms fire and might even be able to withstand RPGs, but anything more powerful, including .50cal machine-guns will be a problem. Such vehicles are primarily used for patrol duty and rapid transport in conflict zones. There isn't much innovation to be seen here other than thicker armour plate and certain forms of ceramic/composite armour.

Medium armour

These vehicles are the bread and butter infantry support vehicles. They feature excellent protection against small arms fire and can even survive hits from older

AT weapons (Anti-Tank). They're usually armed with auto-cannons, grenade launchers and even mortar launchers and TOW (Tube-launched, Optically-tracked, Wire-guided) missile launchers. While such vehicles cannot usually go head-to-head with tanks and other heavily armoured vehicles, they can take out said armoured vehicles if given the opportunity. Of note here is the Stryker I.F.V. (Infantry Fighting Vehicle), a variant of which houses the same 120mm smooth-bore canon that's found on the M1A1 Abrams MBT (Main Battle Tank).

Heavy armour

Now we come to the real meat of the army, the tank, or the Main Battle Tank as it's now known. The tank is quite simply the most fearsome and heavily armoured ground attack vehicle that can be brought to bear. They're the cavalry of the modern age, the armoured spearhead of any major assault. Tanks have evolved quite considerably since they were first introduced in WW1, but essentially, that evolution has taken the form of advanced armour and even more advanced anti-armour ammunition.

ARMOUR AND ARMAMENTS

Modern armoured vehicles are no longer clearly defined in their roles. They're each designed with a primary role in mind, but advanced armour modules and guided missiles have completely reshaped the battlefield, an era where even a foot-soldier is as lethal as the most powerful tank when armed with the right weapon.